
ANI

han Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) cannot be thus converted in use, the BJP-led Assam government has been vehemently opposed to the very idea of a Miya Museum. "How can the *nangol* (plough) be exclusive to Miyas?" asked Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. "Farmers in Sivasagar also use it. Nor is the fishing gear exclusive to them. Except the *lungi*, there is nothing in the museum they can claim as theirs."

A day after the museum was sealed, the police arrested Ali along with AAMP general secretary Abdul Baten and former Aam Aadmi Party convenor Tanu Dhadhumia, who had inaugurated the museum, under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). Ali, a teacher in a local school, was earlier suspended for dereliction of duty. Baten is a retired college teacher from the neighbouring Dhubri district, while Dhadhumia teaches in a junior college in Naharkatia town of Dibrugarh district. Special DGP (law and order) G.P. Singh says they were arrested in connection with a case lodged in Nalbari district for alleged links with persons accused of being cadres of Al Qaeda in Indian Subcontinent (AQIS) and Ansarullah Bangla Team (ABT), a Bangladesh-based terror outfit. The charges, thus, linked up what has been shaping up as a 'culture war' with a more ominous part of the conflict spectrum. This year, Assam Police have arrested nearly 50 terror suspects, including two imams and three madrassa teachers. Five illegally constructed madrassas have been demolished—four by the civic administration and one by locals. As all incidents happened in Muslim-majority districts, it played to the perception that Muslim immigrants are a security threat and CM Sarma declared that Assam was becoming a "hotbed" for Islamist radicals.

> **"How can the *nangol* plough be exclusive to Miyas? Farmers in Sivasagar also use it. Or the fishing rod? Except the *lungi*, there is nothing in the museum they can claim as theirs"**
>
> **HIMANTA BISWA SARMA**
> *Assam chief minister*

IDENTITY AND DEMOGRAPHY

Unlike in the rest of India, where the title 'Mian' can still retain its old sense as a gentlemanly form of address, in Assam it is used exclusively as a pejorative to denote Bangla-speaking Muslims of immigrant origin, mostly inhabiting the *char-chapori* (sandbars and low-lying riverbanks) of the Brahmaputra valley. They are often perceived to be 'illegal immigrants' from Bangladesh, though most claim to have lived in Assam for generations. Assamese nationalist organisations have long been demanding their deportation to Bangladesh.

The fear of Muslims of immigrant origin is rooted in perceptions about demographic growth and the consequent pressure on land and resources. Barring Jammu and Kashmir, presently a Union territory like Lakshadweep, Assam is the state with the highest share of Muslims—now comprising over 34 per cent of the population, up from 25 per cent in 1951.

More importantly, the decadal growth rate of the Muslims in the state has been consistently higher than the national average (see *The Demographic Duel*). Many believe that this is because of immigration from Bangladesh as the fertility rate of Muslims in the state has been seeing a sharp drop. Besides, the decadal population growth rate in all Muslim-majority districts—up from six in 2001 to nine in 2011—has been over 20 per cent, compared to the state average of 17 per cent. Muslims, for instance, comprised 50.22 per cent of Bongaigaon's population in 2011, up from 27.8 per cent in 1971; in Darang, the figure increased from 24 per cent to 64 per cent.

The National Register of Citizens (NRC), which was updated in 2019 in Assam under the supervision of the Supreme Court, took 1971 as the cut-off year for identification of illegal immigrants and found 1.9 million people ineligible for citizenship. Though